

REBELS with a Cause



Denied tickets, senior leaders from across parties are contesting as rebels against their former partymen

| By Swati Mathur and Malini Bhupta |

Never in the history of the Shiv Sena's existence has the Thackeray residence been the target of the cadres' ire. But now Matoshree, the abode of Shiv Sena supremo Bal Thackeray and son and heir Uddhav, has not been spared. There was a time when Sainik rebels and turncoats went into hiding out of fear. Shiv Sena rebels like Sada Sarvankar now joke that when protesting Sainiks land up at Matoshree, the Sena CEO goes into hiding.

Gone are the days when the party's diktat was final. Today, political leaders find nothing wrong in putting their personal interests before that of the party. From floating their own outfits to joining rivals, rebels are doing all they can to spoil the party of the biggies. The rebel phenomenon has touched a new high as major parties sideline loyalists to favour candidates with no political track records. When the only son of India's President Pratibha Patil, Rajendra 'Raosaheb' Shekhawat, decided to contest, the Congress high command gave in meekly. The axe fell on Congress leader Sunil Deshmukh, who will now contest as an independent. Says Deshmukh, "Amravati was a BJP bastion for 15 years. I got a ticket in 1999 and since then Amravati has been transformed." Small wonder then, out of 21 municipal corporators,

19 are supporting Deshmukh.

While paratroopers may be one side of the story in these polls, there are as many rebels as there are causes. Some may have rebelled against their own parties after being denied tickets, but for some others, rebellion is a strategy to undermine the strength of an ally. The fault is of Vilasrao Deshmukh, who spearheaded the Congress-go-it-alone movement that saw the NCP preparing to contest all 288 seats alone. But with the alliance reaffirmed, albeit under the Congress' terms, sentiments of NCP workers have been hurt. Many turned rebel to file nominations against candidates of both the Congress and the NCP. In Palus Kadegaon, where state minister and Congress leader Patangrao Kadam is contesting, NCP rebel and former MLA Prithviraj Deshmukh will give a tough fight to Kadam. Another heavyweight, Digvijay Khanvilkar, state health minister and five-time MLA, is contesting against Congress candidate Satej Patil in Kolhapur South.

Khanvilkar says that the NCP high command had asked him to prepare for the state Assembly elections. By mid-August, he was told that the current elections would be a friendly contest, but the seat went to the Congress, which decided to field Satej. "No official confirmation came to me for



Party Poopers

Constituency Guhagar

BJP MLA Vinay Natu denied ticket. Turns rebel and takes on Shiv Sena's Ramdas Kadam.

Constituency Baosari

NCP Haveli MLA Vilas Lande loses seat in delimitation. He will take on an NCP candidate.

Constituency Mahim

Ex-Shiv Sena MLA Sada Sarvankar joins Congress, will fight Marathi actor Adesh Bandekar.

Constituency Barshi

Ex-NCP minister Dilip Sopal is contesting as an independent against a Congress candidate.

Constituency Radhanagari

NCP candidate K.P. Patil's opponents include the Shiv Sena and four NCP rebels.